

> "Karnataka was one of the earliest states to **add eggs to the school nutrition programme. It's basically a game-changer as far as nutrition levels in food go**, and in terms of the state's interventions to reduce malnutrition"
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> **V. Rashmi Mahesh,** *Additional Chief Secretary, Dept of School Education and Literacy, Karnataka*



> "Eggs are the most **important protein and energy source, especially in a child's diet,** but often neglected at homes"
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> **Srinivasa Rao**
> *Director, MDM and School Sanitation, School Education Department, Andhra Pradesh*

THE 'EGGVANTAGE'

The nutrition argument for eggs remains strong. One egg provides 6-7 grams of high biological-value protein containing all nine essential amino acids, alongside vitamins B12 and D, choline, selenium and fat. Children who do not eat eggs, says Dr B.N. Singh, director of internal medicine at Fortis Hospital Faridabad, can get protein from milk, curd, paneer, lentils, chickpeas, rajma, soybeans, nuts, seeds and cereal-pulse combinations, provided the diet is varied, the quantities adequate and the meals properly planned.

But that caveat is the heart of the matter. A carefully planned household diet is one thing, a government school meal is another. Dr Saurabh Gupta, associate director of internal medicine at Yashoda Medicity, says that replacing eggs is not only about protein; vitamins B12 and D, and choline must also be replaced. "The key is not that every meal must contain all essential amino acids," he says. "What matters is combining different protein sources across the day." Public health specialist Dr Srikantia Sridhar puts it more bluntly: "Is egg essential in a child's diet? No, it is not. But whatever replaces eggs has a much more complicated logistical challenge. Monitoring, maintaining consistency, quantity and quality of that food requires the system to work much harder." It is not that vegetarian food cannot nourish. It can. It is that a boiled egg is measurable, visible and difficult to fake. Dal can be watery. Soya can be a few token chunks. Paneer can disappear into procurement irregularity. As for milk, it's idiomatic for dilution—and, in its best form, needs cold chains. Most fruit won't have enough protein.

The string of controversies in recent years has also done little to bridge the trust deficit in PM POSHAN delivery. These range from an alleged Rs 2,000 crore procurement scam in Rajasthan; a probe into green peas being substituted with lower-quality produce in Maharashtra; children hospitalised after suspected food poisoning in Bihar and Rajasthan; a dead lizard found in a school meal in Delhi; worms reported in foodgrains in Karnataka; and allegations of rotten eggs being served in Jharkhand. The broader learning is not that eggs are unsafe or vegetarian meals are inherently safer. It is that every item on the school plate—eggs, dal, peas, rice or milk—demands transparent procurement, rigorous food-safety checks and regular nutritional audits.

No child should be forced to eat something against family belief. Nor should any child be deprived because of another family's beliefs. Child rights demand that the State be neutral and enable choice. The trouble arises when the debate in some states moves beyond choice into identity. In UP, food choices have acquired cultural meaning. The state's One District, One Cuisine initiative promotes vegetarian district dishes while leaving out globally known meat-based traditions such as Lucknow's Galouti and Kakori kebabs, Rampuri cuisine and Moradabadi biryani. Critics see this as part of a broader projection of vegetarian public culture. Sociologist Amita Baviskar points out that only some sections of certain forward and mid-ranking castes among Hindus traditionally practised lacto-vegetarianism; most Hindus are non-vegetarian. Thus, the Hindu nationalist insistence on vegetarianism does not reflect Hindu practice in its totality—rather, only a Jaina-influenced band within it. Even the word 'Brahminical', often laid against it, is a misnomer since Brahmins across several regions are non-vegetarian.

Bengal's course correction shows nutrition priorities can outweigh ideology. That should be the national principle. India does not need compulsory vegetarianism but compulsory seriousness about child nutrition. The state's duty is not to impose a menu of faith, caste or convenience, it is to ensure that the poorest child gets the best possible nutrition at the lowest possible cost, with respect for family choice but without surrendering public policy to the loudest dietary veto. PM POSHAN should remain a nutrition programme and not another battlefield in the politics of the plate. ■

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